

Early Chinese art

From c.1550 BCE, China experienced its first cultural Golden Age. The earliest Chinese writing was developed and organically-shaped bronze vessels were produced. Around 210 BCE, thousands of life-sized terracotta sculptures were buried with the First Emperor, Qin Shi Huang, to protect him in the afterlife. The greatest achievements came in the Tang Dynasty (618–906 CE), when both trade and art flourished. Often called the classical period of Chinese art, new palaces, temples, pagodas and tombs were built, and adorned with sculpture, paintings, carvings, textiles, glass and metalwork. Rather than realism, painters aimed to capture the spirit of their subjects. Through China's trading success, ideas were exchanged between countries. For the first time, painters created not only religious images, but also landscapes, known as *shan shui* ('mountain-water'), and scenes from history and court life. They focused on flowing lines to portray movement with delicate brush and ink work conveying atmosphere. Two of the most expressive were Wang Wei (699–759) and Wu Daozi (fl.710–760).



Terracotta warriors, c.210 BCE